

Special Licence: Project application form



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Definitions

Licence holder: the licence holder(s) specified in section 1.

Data depositor: depositor of the studies detailed in section 2.3.

Data: the special licence study numbers detailed in section 2.3.

Dispute arbitrator: The Economic and Social Research Council (ESRC).

How to complete this form

This application form should be completed by the project lead. The project lead will be the single point of contact for the UK Data Service in relation to this project both at the application stage, and through the full lifetime of the project. The project lead will be contacted with reminders about project expiries, and must submit any extension requests, or requests to vary the project or project team members.

For a research project being undertaken by academics the project lead **does not** have to be the Principal Investigator. Where there is funding associated with a project the project lead **does not** have to be the award holder.

Our [example application](#) shows the level of information that data owners expect to see in a well written application.

If more than one person is involved in the project and will have access to the data your are applying for, list them in section 1.2 and ensure **each additional** team member completes the Special Licence additional researcher form.

Only list individuals who **will see the raw data** in Section 1.2.

If you are a student conducting research related to your studies your supervisor **only** needs to be listed in Section 1.2 if they will be consulting the raw data.

We recommend the project lead liaises with all project team members to finalise the project details and ensures all necessary documentation is gathered before submitting to the UK Data Service by email to help@ukdataservice.ac.uk.

The project lead and **all** individuals listed in Section 1.2 must **also** complete and submit a signed UK Data Service Special Licence User Agreement.

1. About your project

UK Data Service project number <i>This is found on your UK Data Service account</i>	282609
Project title	Work from home in the UK
Project start date <i>When do you want to start working with the data?</i>	07/05/2026
Project end date <i>When do you plan to complete your project work?</i>	31/12/2029
Is your project funded? <i>Funding is not mandatory but provides additional reassurance for the project</i>	No
If yes, which organisation/institution is funding the research?	

Project lead/project team details:

1.1 Project lead

Please list the details of the project lead as listed on the UK Data Service website.

First name(s)	Itay
Surname	Saporta Eksten
Institution/Organisation	University of Manchester
Institution/Organisation address	The University of Manchester Oxford Road Manchester M13 9PL
Telephone number	07707784380

Email <i>This must be the email address associated with your UK Data Service user account</i>	itay.saportaeksten@manchester.ac.uk
Location of access <i>Please state the site of access for the project lead. Include the address of where the data will be hosted and stored, including your organisation/institution name</i>	Data will be stored and processed on a secure desktop computer located in a locked office at: The Eitan Berglas School of Economics Tel Aviv University, Ramat Aviv 6997801 ISRAEL The data will be accessed remotely by me via Tel Aviv University's secure VPN system from the following locations: The University of Manchester Oxford Road Manchester M13 9PL My home office: 14 Victoria rd. London N22 7XB The data will be accessed remotely by the research student via Tel Aviv University's secure VPN system from the following locations: The Eitan Berglas School of Economics Tel Aviv University, Ramat Aviv 6997801 ISRAEL His home office at: 140 Arlozorov st., Tel Aviv-Yaffo, 6209821 Israel

Measures in place to protect the data <i>Refer to section 4.1.1 (on page 8) of the Research data handling and security guide for users when completing this section.</i>	The data will be stored and processed on a Tel Aviv university-managed desktop computer located in a locked office at Tel Aviv University. Access to the data will be limited to approved project members and will be conducted remotely via Tel Aviv University's secure VPN using personal user accounts with two-factor authentication. Remote access sessions will be initiated only when required and will be closed when not in use. No data will be stored on personal laptops, external drives, or cloud storage services. All processing will take place on the institutional computer, and no data will be downloaded or transferred outside the secure environment. The institutional computer is encrypted (BitLocker) and protected by password authentication. The system is configured to automatically lock after a short period of inactivity and requires authentication to regain access. The system receives regular security updates and is protected by anti-malware software. At the end of the project, all data will be securely deleted in accordance with UK Data Service requirements.
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Please note: Home working access is available for some Special Licence data, see [Special Licence home working arrangements](#), and the list of studies approved for home working access. If home working access is required, complete the Appendix of the Special Licence User Agreement.

1.2 Research team

In addition to the project lead details given above, please list the names and email address of all member(s) of your research team who **will access** the data.

- All researchers listed below should be invited to the project on the [UK Data Service website](https://ukdataservice.ac.uk).
- Each person listed below will need to complete a Special Licence additional researcher form **and** a Special Licence User Agreement.

Name	Email address
Ori Nahshon Shoham	orishoham@mail.tau.ac.il

Add additional rows to the table if necessary.

2. Project details

The information you provide here will be used by the data owner to make a decision about whether or not to approve your application to use this data.

2.1 Abstract

Using plain language, without jargon, please include a short description of the project and its benefits.

Gender gaps in earnings and careers remain a central economic and social problem. A central hypothesis is that the division of labour inside the household is the primary cause of those gaps. This project studies whether temporary shocks to household specialization when children are young, at the beginning of parenthood, can durably change the later division of labour within the household, and whether such changes have causal effects on gender gaps in labour market outcomes and parents' career trajectories.

We exploit exogenous variation created by the COVID-19 pandemic, which sharply changed the allocation of paid work and caregiving across couples depending on the pre-pandemic sectors and occupations in which mothers and fathers were employed. We will use a difference-in-differences event study design that determines treatment status based on the pre-COVID sector exposure to COVID regulations and an instrumental variable design that combines pre-COVID exposure with local restrictions to instrument for work location.

2.2 Research proposal

Please provide a full and detailed description of the purpose for which the data are requested, describing the aims of the project. Where research is part of a larger programme, please include details below.

Research question and contribution.

This project studies whether COVID-induced changes in mothers' and fathers' paid-work location and availability altered the division of unpaid work within couples, and whether any changes persisted after the acute pandemic period. The pandemic created sharp, externally driven variation across households: some parents continued working outside the home as key workers, some shifted to home working, and others faced shutdowns or furlough. Because these shocks depended strongly on pre-pandemic industry, occupation and local restrictions, they provide a credible setting for studying causal effects on household labour allocation.

We focus on co-resident couples, especially couples with dependent children observed before the pandemic. Understanding Society is uniquely suited to this design because it links partners within households, follows them before, during and after COVID-19, and provides the detailed Special Licence industry, occupation and Local Authority District information needed to define pre-pandemic exposure and local policy conditions and the time use measures needed to study the division of household labor.

Treatment construction from pre-pandemic employment.

Treatment status will be constructed using only information measured before the pandemic, primarily each partner's Standard Industrial Classification (SIC) and Standard Occupational Classification (SOC) codes relying on the Office for National Statistics key-worker classification and the Institute for Fiscal Studies classification of shutdown sectors (Joyce and Xu, 2020). We will classify jobs into exposure groups such as key-worker sectors, shutdown sectors, and occupations with high or low capacity to work from home. The analysis will use couple-level contrasts such as: (i) wife is a key worker in a non-education sector while the husband is not a key worker or is in education only; and (ii) husband is in a shutdown sector while the wife is not (with analogous symmetric contrasts defined for husbands and wives, respectively). These definitions are designed to capture asymmetric shocks to the amount of time each partner was required or able to spend at home during the early pandemic.

We will also estimate models that treat the realised work-location configuration of the couple as endogenous. Specifically, we will study combinations of wife's and husband's work location/status during the pandemic, including wife at home/husband at home, wife at home/husband working outside the home, wife working outside the home/husband at home, and wife working outside the home/husband working outside the home. Realised work location is not randomly assigned: parents may select into working from home, reduce hours, or leave employment in response to household needs. We will therefore estimate instrumental-variable specifications using pre-pandemic industry and occupation exposure, interacted with pandemic timing and local restrictions, as instruments for these realised couple work-location states.

Descriptive and event-study specification.

The first empirical step will document how outcomes evolve around the pandemic by treatment group and by spouse. Outcomes include labour market, childcare and family outcomes such as: employment, work hours, weekly hours, wages, work location, housework hours, childcare hours, responsibility for childcare, selected health and well-being outcomes as well as divorces and childbirths. Let c index couples, s index spouse (wife or husband), t index wave or interview month, and Y_{cst} denote an outcome for spouse s in couple c at time t . Let T_c be a pre-pandemic couple exposure indicator, such as wife key worker/husband not key worker, and let $r(t)$ denote event time relative to the onset of the pandemic. The event-study model will be:

$$Y_{cst} = \lambda_t + \sum_{\{r \neq -1\}} \beta_{\{r,s\}} [1\{r(t) = r\} \times T_c] + W'_{cst} \Gamma_s + \varepsilon_{cst}.$$

Here λ_t are time fixed effects and W_{cst} is a vector of controls. This vector includes pre-pandemic controls such as both partners' age, education, number of children, age of youngest child, region, and baseline employment characteristics. Depending on the specification, W_{cst} may also include couple fixed effects or couple-by-spouse fixed effects. The omitted event-time category is the pre-pandemic period immediately before COVID-19. The coefficients $\beta_{\{r,s\}}$ trace how the outcome for each spouse changes in treated couples relative to comparison couples. We will estimate the specification separately for wives and husbands and, where useful, in a stacked couple-spouse format that allows direct tests of whether effects differ by gender within the same couple.

This design also provides diagnostic evidence on pre-trends. If the pre-pandemic $\beta_{\{r,s\}}$ coefficients are close to zero for labour-market and household-work outcomes, that supports the interpretation that post-pandemic differences reflect the COVID shock rather than pre-existing divergent trends. Where pre-trends are present, we will report them and use more conservative specifications, including richer baseline controls, spouse-specific trends, or narrower comparison groups. In separate specification we will interact treatment and event time with indicators for the age of the youngest kid the couple has at the onset of the pandemic to test whether effects are different for couples with young vs. older children.

Instrumental-variable design for realised work-location states.

The second empirical step will estimate the effect of actual pandemic work-location configurations on household outcomes. Let D_c^q be an indicator that couple c is in realised state q in the COVID period, where q indexes the different combinations of wife's and husband's at-home/work-outside status. Because D_c^q may be correlated with unobserved preferences, job security, bargaining power or childcare constraints, we will instrument these endogenous states using predicted exposure from pre-COVID SIC/SOC and local COVID restrictions. The first stage will be:

$$D_c^q = \pi_q' Z_{c,pre} + \delta_q R_l + \kappa_q' (Z_{c,pre} \times R_l) + W_c' \eta_q + u_c^q.$$

$Z_{c,pre}$ contains spouse-specific predicted pandemic exposure based on pre-COVID industry and occupation, such as wife's predicted key-worker status, husband's predicted key-worker status, wife's predicted shutdown-sector exposure, husband's predicted shutdown-sector exposure, and each partner's predicted capacity to work from home. R_l denotes local restrictions in Local Authority l during COVID, including school closures and other restrictions relevant to workplaces and childcare. The interactions $Z_{c,pre} \times R_l$ allow the same pre-pandemic job to have different implications depending on the local policy environment at the time of interview. W_c denotes the corresponding first-stage controls vector, again allowing couple fixed effects where they are part of the chosen specification and not collinear with the excluded instruments.

The second stage will be:

$$Y_{cst} = \sum_q \theta_{\{q,s\}} \widehat{D}_c^q + \rho_s R_l + W_{ct}' \Gamma_s + \varepsilon_{cst}.$$

The coefficients $\theta_{\{q,s\}}$ estimate how different realised couple work-location configurations affect each spouse's outcomes such as paid work, unpaid work and well-being at different horizons t , for the variation in work-location states induced by pre-pandemic job exposure and local restrictions. For example, this design will allow us to test whether a father being at home while a mother continues to work outside the home increases the father's childcare or housework contribution, whether any reallocation persists after restrictions end, and whether the mother's later labour supply or earnings respond to the temporary change in household specialization.

Role of local restrictions and data linkage.

Local Authority District identifiers are required to assign households to time-varying local COVID restrictions. These restrictions are central to the empirical design for two reasons. First, they measure direct constraints on childcare and work, such as school closures, workplace restrictions and lockdown intensity. Second, they create additional quasi-experimental variation in the relevance of pre-pandemic industry and occupation. A parent in an occupation that can be done remotely is more likely to work from home when restrictions are binding; a parent in a shutdown sector is more likely to experience reduced work when local restrictions close that activity; and school closures increase the household value of a parent being physically at home. Region-level geography is too coarse for this purpose because restrictions varied across local areas and over time. Region is the finest geography released under the standard End User Licence; Local Authority District identifiers are available only under the Special Licence, and are therefore essential to this part of the design.

Detailed industry and occupation codes are equally fundamental, for two reasons. First, they define the treatment groups: the core treatment variables - key-worker, shutdown-sector, and capacity to work from home - are constructed from the full SIC and SOC codes, because COVID-19 regulations differentiated finely within

broad groups that coarser classifications cannot capture, as essential and non-essential retail, or frontline and administrative healthcare roles, share the same broad category but faced very different obligations to attend work. Broader groupings would misclassify workers into the wrong treatment category, contaminating the comparison and biasing estimate. The standard End User Licence releases industry and occupation only at a coarse level, which would collapse these policy-relevant distinctions; the full detailed SIC and SOC codes are available only under the Special Licence, and are therefore essential to the exposure indicators underlying the design.

Expected contribution and references.

The project contributes to research on the sources of gender inequality and child penalties by asking whether shocks to household specialization can have lasting effects. The design is motivated by evidence that labour-market gender gaps are closely linked to job flexibility and family responsibilities (Goldin, 2014) and that the arrival of children is associated with large and persistent gender gaps in earnings and careers (Kleven, Landais, Posch, Steinhauer and Zweimuller, 2019). It also builds on COVID-era evidence that the pandemic changed paid work, care and childcare arrangements within UK households (Hupkau and Petrongolo, 2020; Sevilla and Smith, 2020). Our contribution is to use detailed Special Licence industry, occupation and local geography to move beyond descriptive gender differences and estimate how exogenously induced changes in each partner's work location affected the intra-household division of labour and later outcomes.

References:

Goldin, C. (2014), 'A Grand Gender Convergence: Its Last Chapter', *American Economic Review* 104(4): 1091-1119.

Kleven, H., C. Landais, J. Posch, A. Steinhauer and J. Zweimuller (2019), 'Child Penalties across Countries: Evidence and Explanations', *AEA Papers and Proceedings* 109: 122-126.

Hupkau, C. and B. Petrongolo (2020), 'Work, Care and Gender During the COVID-19 Crisis', *Fiscal Studies* 41(3): 623-651.

Sevilla, A. and S. Smith (2020), 'Baby Steps: The Gender Division of Childcare during the COVID-19 Pandemic', *Oxford Review of Economic Policy* 36(S1): S169-S186.

Office for National Statistics (2020), 'Coronavirus and Key Workers in the UK: Key Workers Reference Tables', ONS, <https://www.ons.gov.uk/employmentandlabourmarket/peopleinwork/earningsandworkinghours/datasets/keyworkersreferencetables>.

Joyce, R. and X. Xu (2020), 'Sector Shutdowns during the Coronavirus Crisis: Which Workers Are Most Exposed?', IFS Briefing Note BN278, Institute for Fiscal Studies, <https://ifs.org.uk/publications/sector-shutdowns-during-coronavirus-crisis-which-workers-are-most-exposed>.

2.3 Data required for the project

List the UK Data Service study number and full study title.

In this section you only need to detail Special Licence studies required (data subject to the Special Licence user agreement). For example: [SN 6931 - Understanding Society: Waves 1-14, 2009-2023 and Harmonised BHPS: Waves 1-18, 1991-2009: Special Licence Access](#).

SN 6931 - Understanding Society: Waves 1-15, 2009-2024 and Harmonised BHPS: Waves 1-18, 1991-2009: Special Licence Access

SN 6666 - Understanding Society: Waves 1-15, 2009-2024 and Harmonised BHPS: Waves 1-18, 1991-2009: Special Licence Access, Local Authority District

2.4 Justification

Please provide a justification as to why you are requesting access to the data listed in section 2.3. You should include:

- An explanation as to why you require these data, including information about specific variables or questions of interest and how you'll use these in your research.
- An explanation demonstrating that you have considered alternative sources of data, and reasons why these data are not sufficient for your research.

IMPORTANT: when applying for social survey data, we strongly recommend that you consider using less restrictive versions of the data that are available. Please visit the [UK Data Service catalogue](#) to locate less restrictive sources, where available.

This project requires access to the Special Licence version of Understanding Society in order to obtain detailed industry and occupation identifiers for both partners within households. The empirical design relies on constructing measures of exposure to COVID-19 sectoral restrictions at the industry–occupation level, including classification into sectors subject to shutdowns, essential/key worker sectors requiring work outside the home, and occupations with the capacity to transition to remote work.

To implement this classification, we require access to the full Standard Industrial Classification (SIC) and Standard Occupational Classification (SOC) codes (e.g., jbsic07, jobsoc00) available under the Special Licence. The broader industry and occupation groupings in the End User Licence (EUL) version do not provide sufficient detail to distinguish between sub-sectors that were differentially affected by pandemic restrictions (for example, essential versus non-essential retail, frontline versus non-frontline healthcare, or occupations with differing remote-work feasibility). The detailed codes are therefore necessary to construct accurate exposure measures.

In addition, the project requires Local Authority District identifiers to link households to external data on local COVID-19 restrictions, including school closures. The EUL version provides geographical information only at the Government Office Region level, which is too aggregated to capture this variation. Access to Local Authority identifiers is therefore necessary to construct accurate measures of local policy exposure.

A further key feature of Understanding Society is the ability to link pre-pandemic employment information to the Understanding Society COVID-19 Study waves. This linkage allows us to examine short-term adjustments in employment status, working from home, childcare responsibilities, and health, and to analyse the mechanisms underlying changes in household labour allocation. Alternative UK datasets do not combine detailed couple-level panel data with both employment detail and pandemic-specific survey waves.

We have considered less restrictive data versions and alternative sources; however, the EUL version does not provide sufficient detail in industry, occupation, or geography to implement the proposed design. The Special Licence version is therefore required.

2.5 Does your project proposal include any linking of data sources?

If yes, please provide the following details below:

- A description of the data source(s) to be linked to the data.
- A summary of the key variables.
- A summary of the linking methodology.

- Justification for the linking.

The project will link Understanding Society data to the Institute for Fiscal Studies (IFS) COVID-19 Restrictions Dataset, which provides detailed information on the timing and intensity of local policy measures in the UK, including school closures, restrictions on economic activity, and social distancing measures at the Local Authority District level.

Key variables from this dataset include indicators of primary and secondary school closures, as well as measures of restrictions affecting workplaces and social interactions. These variables vary over time and across Local Authorities.

Linkage will be conducted using Local Authority District identifiers available in the Special Licence version of Understanding Society. Households will be matched to the corresponding Local Authority, and policy variables will be assigned based on the timing of the interview.

This linkage is necessary to incorporate variation in local policy environments into the analysis and to examine how differences in school closures and other restrictions affected intra-household labour allocation.

2.6 Expected outputs

Please give details of the products/outputs that will be produced from your use of the data. This might include things like: analysis, reports, tables, journal articles, books, chapters, blog posts or theses. If applicable, please describe the impact and public benefit which you expect will occur as a result of your use of the data.

The primary outputs of this project will be empirical analysis of changes in intra-household labour allocation associated with differential exposure to COVID-19 sectoral restrictions and local policy measures. We will produce statistical estimates of how asymmetric shocks to presence at home within couples affected short and long run outcomes, including employment status, working hours, childcare responsibilities, and domestic work, with particular attention to parents of young children.

The results will be presented in the form of regression estimates, summary tables, and figures. We intend to prepare one or more academic papers for submission to peer-reviewed journals in economics or related social sciences. The findings may also be presented at academic conferences and seminars.

By providing evidence on whether temporary gender role reversals can alter patterns of household labour division, the project aims to contribute to policy discussions on gender equality, family policy, and labour market resilience in response to large economic disruptions.

2.7 Protection of confidentiality

Describe the methods you will use to determine whether the outputs listed in Section 2.6 above are disclosive and the measures you will use to protect confidentiality in those outputs.

Methods and standards specified in the [Research data handling and security guide for users](#) and [Office for National Statistics's Disclosure control for tables produced from surveys](#) must be applied to statistical outputs.

All analysis will comply with the UK Data Service Research Data Handling and Security: Guide for Users and the Office for National Statistics guidance on disclosure control for survey data outputs.

The detailed industry, occupation, and geographical variables accessed under the Special Licence will be used to construct categorical exposure indicators and as well as for heterogeneity analysis. No outputs will include disaggregated SIC or SOC classifications or detailed geographical identifiers beyond broad analytical groupings necessary for interpretation.

We will not report tabulations or summary statistics based on small cells. Where necessary, categories will be aggregated to prevent disclosure risk. No outputs will identify individual respondents, households, employers, or small geographic areas.

Regression results will report coefficients, standard errors, and overall sample sizes. No individual-level data will be shared. All outputs will consist solely of aggregated statistical summaries that comply with applicable disclosure control standards.

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